



Lesson 2: Define Your Strengths and Direction

What You're Doing Today

Last lesson, you found every trace of your work that's already out there — GitHub repos, Lumexa missions, Canva designs, deployed sites. Today you turn that list into something useful: an honest answer to *"what am I actually good at, and what should my portfolio focus on?"*

You are not inventing a personality or picking a job for life. You're reading your own evidence and choosing one honest, provable direction to build your portfolio around for the rest of this course.

Why This Matters

A portfolio that claims things you can't back up falls apart the moment someone asks a follow-up question. A portfolio built on real evidence — even small evidence — holds up, because you can always show the receipts. This lesson is about finding the receipts you already have.

Three Kinds of "Good At"

It's easy to mix these up. They're not the same thing, and a strong portfolio treats them differently.

Level	What it means	What counts as evidence	Example
Interest	Something you're curious about or enjoy	None required	"I think game design looks cool."
Strength	Something you're noticeably better at, or improve faster at, than your other work	A pattern across 2+ attempts, or solid feedback	"My CSS layouts always come out cleaner than my other project parts."
Proven skill	Something you can point to a finished, working thing to demonstrate	One or more completed artifacts	"Here's a Vercel site I built and styled myself."

The rule: your portfolio direction should be led by proven skills, backed up by strengths, and can mention interests only as "what I want to learn next" — never claimed as if they're already true.

Worked Example (Fictional Student)

Note: "Jordan R." is a made-up example used for teaching. Not a real Lumexa student.

Jordan looked at their project list from Lesson 1:

1. Lumexa Mission "Space Weather Dashboard" — HTML/CSS, styled with Canva graphics, deployed to Vercel
2. Lumexa Mission "Simple Platformer Game" — finished, but the jump mechanic is buggy; Jordan's only game project
3. Personal project — redesigned a birthday invitation in Canva for family
4. Lumexa Mission "Personal Portfolio Starter Page" — HTML/CSS, deployed to Vercel, got positive instructor feedback on layout
5. Group project — helped a teammate fix color scheme and spacing in their CSS (not Jordan's own repo)

Jordan's honest read:

- Projects 1, 3, 4, and 5 all involve visual layout and styling — that's the *same skill showing up four times*, across different tools and contexts. That's a real strength.
- Project 2 is a genuine finished game, but it's the *only* one, and it has a known bug. That's an interest with a little early proof — not yet a strength.
- Direction: **front-end web development / visual design** — because the evidence repeats and includes outside positive feedback.
- Game dev goes in the "still want to learn" list — real, but not yet backed by enough evidence to lead the portfolio.

Notice what Jordan did **not** do: claim to be a "full-stack game developer" because one buggy platformer sounded impressive. The direction follows the evidence, not the excitement.

Step-by-Step Activity

Open your Worksheet and your Lesson 1 audit notes, then work through these steps in order.

Step 1: List every project

Every Lumexa mission, every personal project, every time you helped someone else with code or design — even unfinished ones. Put each in the inventory table.

Step 2: Tag what each one demonstrates

For each project, write down the actual skill it shows — be specific ("CSS layout and spacing," not just "coding").

Step 3: Set an honest confidence level

For each project, mark your confidence: **High** (I could do this again reliably), **Medium** (I did it once, with help or some struggle), or **Low** (I tried, it's rough, or someone else did most of it).

Step 4: Cluster into a direction

Look for a skill that shows up in **two or more** projects at Medium or High confidence. That repeat pattern is your strength cluster. Pick one (or at most two, if they're closely related) to be your portfolio direction.

Step 5: Write your direction statement

Use the template on your Worksheet. Keep it to 1–2 sentences, and make sure you can point to specific projects that back it up.

Step 6: Park your other interests

List things you're genuinely excited about but can't yet prove. These go in "what I still want to learn" — not deleted, just set aside for now.

Key Terms Glossary

- **Interest** — something you're curious about or enjoy; requires no evidence to claim.
- **Strength** — a skill you're noticeably better at than your other work, shown by a repeating pattern across multiple projects.
- **Proven skill** — a skill backed by at least one finished, working artifact you can show someone.
- **Direction** — the honest focus area you choose to build your portfolio around right now, based on your strongest evidence.
- **Confidence level** — your own honest rating (High/Medium/Low) of how solid your evidence is for a given project.
- **Strength cluster** — a group of two or more projects that all demonstrate the same underlying skill.

Knowledge Check

1. What is the main difference between an "interest" and a "strength"?
2. Why is claiming an interest as a "proven skill" a problem for a portfolio?
3. In the Jordan R. example, why didn't Jordan pick "game developer" as their direction, even though the platformer game was a real finished project?
4. What makes a group of projects count as a genuine "strength cluster" rather than just one lucky project?
5. Where should a real interest go if you don't have enough evidence yet to call it a strength?

Reflection Prompts

1. Was there a project you almost left off your inventory because it felt too small or unfinished to count? What made you decide either way?

2. Did the direction your evidence pointed to match what you expected before you started, or did it surprise you?
 3. If someone asked you right now to prove your direction statement using only what you've already built, what would you show them first?
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Submission Instructions

Submit your completed Worksheet (Strengths & Direction Map) through the Lumexa classroom portal before the next live session. Make sure it includes: a filled-in project inventory table, at least one clearly identified strength cluster, a completed direction statement, and a "what I still want to learn" section. Bring a digital or printed copy to Lesson 3 — you'll build your portfolio structure directly from your direction statement.